

Big losses for civil rights at high court

Most cases involving women and minorities rejected, analysis shows

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL

The sharply conservative Supreme Court that President Donald Trump's three appointees remade is the first since at least the 1950s to reject civil rights claims in a majority of cases involving women and minorities, according to a detailed analysis conducted for The Washington Post.

The shift brings to an end a streak of successive courts expanding such protections that began with the dawn of the civil rights era. But the historic nature of the current court is also evident in other key areas of the law over the five terms since the third of Trump's appointees joined the bench.

The analysis shows that in addition to civil rights, the court powered by Trump's picks — Justices Neil M. Gorsuch, Brett M. Kavanaugh and Amy Coney Barrett — has pushed to the right of any modern court on religious rights and voting issues.

The court has also entered a new era of extreme partisanship. None over the past seven decades has been as starkly polarized.

"There is no center now," said political science professor Lee Epstein, who performed the analysis with her Washington University colleague Andrew D. Martin and Michael J. Nelson of Penn State.

A yawning gulf has opened between the left and right flanks of the court, Epstein said.

"The polarization in American society seeps into the Senate. It seeps into the presidency. It is naturally going to seep into the courts. It would be surprising to see another John Paul Stevens," Epstein said, referring to the late justice noted for his moderation. "Partisan identity and ideology have become so intertwined."

The analysis examined 270 decisions handed down by the Supreme Court between 2020 and 2024 — the first five terms of the six-justice conservative majority — and drew on the Supreme Court Database, a compendium of cases the professors maintain.

The professors compared that data to the body of rulings under Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. before 2020, as well as rulings handed down under the six other chief justices dating back to the New Deal era. The analysis did not include rulings from the current term or orders in cases on the

SEE SUPREME COURT ON A8



HASSAN AMMAR/AP



AMMAR AWAD/REUTERS



VAHID SALEMI/AP

Mourners at a funeral Thursday in Beirut carry the coffin of a person killed in an Israeli airstrike. An Israeli tank on the border with Lebanon on Thursday. Israel and Lebanon have not held direct talks to normalize relations since 1983, which led to a deal that quickly collapsed. Girls in Tehran sing Thursday at a ceremony marking the 40th day since the death of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

Iranians fly flags of victory after pause in attacks

TRUMP'S CENTRAL WAR AIMS REMAIN UNMET

He launched conflict demanding complete surrender

BY STEVE HENDRIX

LONDON — Shortly after President Donald Trump threatened to erase the "whole civilization" of Iran, all 6,000 years of it, the crowds came out into the streets of Tehran waving flags — and not white ones. They bore the green, white and red banners of the still-standing Islamic Republic. Some set fire to the star-spangled ones of the superpower that, according to state media, they had just "humiliated."

Whatever the outcome of the unstable two-week ceasefire that the United States and Iran agreed to just before Trump's apocalyptic deadline — whether it becomes an enduring truce or a return to the violence that has upended life from Israel to Azerbaijan — the pause in hostilities did not begin with images of an "unconditional surrender" that the president repeatedly demanded.

Exhausted Iranians may yet get a fortnight's respite from airstrikes, but Trump's central war objectives remain unmet, and hard questions are left unresolved. Each side is claiming victory, but neither is a clear winner.

Trump launched Operation Epic Fury on Feb. 28 demanding unconditional surrender, the elim-

ination of Iran's nuclear program and the destruction of its ballistic missiles. He, along with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, said they hoped the attacks would lead to regime change.

By those measures, Wednesday's scorecard after nearly six weeks of bombing makes for sober reading.

Iran is battered but unbroken. The regime has not collapsed; it has hardened. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps still has weapons to fire, including ballistic missiles shot at Israel and Persian Gulf states in the hours after the ceasefire was announced, injuring two teenagers in Beersheba, Israel. Somewhere in Iran, a few hundred kilograms of enriched uranium remains as prospective raw material for a nuclear weapon.

Trump's obvious and growing frustrations over Iran's death grip on oil shipments through the Strait of Hormuz and spiking gasoline prices for increasingly disaffected voters led him to bring genocidal rhetoric to the social media feed of the American presidency. Iran's beleaguered leaders,

SEE IRAN ON A12

No place to go: Not everyone is welcome in Lebanon's shelters. A11

Israel, Lebanon to enter talks as attacks continue

Netanyahu says goals are to normalize relations and disarm Hezbollah

BY SAMMY WESTFALL, SUZAN HAIDAMOUS, MOHAMAD EL CHAMAA AND LIOR SOROKA

JERUSALEM — While insisting that Israel's attacks on Hezbollah in Lebanon would continue, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Thursday that he had authorized direct talks with Lebanon focused on disarming Hezbollah and "the formalization of peaceful relations" between Israel and Lebanon.

"In light of Lebanon's repeated requests to open direct negotia-

tions with Israel, I instructed the Cabinet yesterday to initiate direct talks with Lebanon as soon as possible," Netanyahu posted on X, adding: "Israel appreciates the call made today by the Prime Minister of Lebanon to demilitarize Beirut."

Israel and Lebanon have not held direct talks with a goal of normalizing relations since U.S.-mediated talks in 1983, which led to an agreement that quickly collapsed.

Israeli Ambassador to the United States Yechiel Leiter will lead the negotiations for Israel, a person familiar with the details said, who like others spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to the press.

Netanyahu's announcement came as he otherwise appeared to

SEE LEBANON ON A14

DOJ continues push to search Post reporter's phone, laptops

BY PERRY STEIN

Federal prosecutors on Thursday urged a judge to overturn a ruling barring the Justice Department from directly searching a Washington Post reporter's electronic devices seized as part of an investigation into a government contractor accused of leaking classified materials.

The hearing in front of U.S. District Judge Anthony J. Trenga in the Eastern District of Virginia marked the government's latest attempt to convince the court that it should have the authority to conduct a tailored search of Post reporter Hannah Natanson's phone, computers and other devices to

look for information relevant to its investigation of the contractor.

Magistrate Judge William Porter had ruled in February that the government could not search the devices, which all sides have agreed contain years of Natanson's materials that she's gathered covering the federal government. Instead, he ruled, the court would conduct a search on behalf of the government, citing the possibility that the Justice Department could wrongly look at more information than the warrant allows either by "neglect, by malice, or by honest difference of opinion."

The Justice Department appealed that ruling, kicking the

SEE DOJ ON A8



DAVID J. PHILLIP/AP

Eyeing more green

Defending Masters champion Rory McIlroy shot a 5-under 67 to share the lead after the first round at Augusta National. Story, B7

USDA chief's 'He is Risen' Easter email unnerves some

BY MARIANA ALFARO, MICHELLE BOORSTEIN AND MERYL KORNFIELD

Employees at the U.S. Department of Agriculture were greeted Monday by a rare — and what some saw as an alarming — email from the department's secretary, Brooke Rollins.

"Happy Easter — He is Risen indeed!" starts the email, which was reviewed by The Washington Post. It appears to have been written on Easter Sunday and was sent to the roughly 100,000 federal workers across USDA. "Today we celebrate the greatest story ever told, the foundation of our faith, and the abiding hope of

all mankind."

"From the foot of the Cross on Good Friday to the stone rolled away from the now empty tomb, sin has been destroyed," continues the email, signed by Rollins. "Jesus has been raised from the dead. And God has granted each of us victory and new life. And where there is life — risen life — there is hope."

The USDA email was the latest in a string of seemingly unprecedented expressions of Christian proselytizing by an administration that has made it a hallmark — not just in the federal workplace but also across the world.

In March, Defense Secretary

SEE EASTER ON A6

IN THE NEWS

First lady speaks Melania Trump, in a rare news briefing, denied that she had a close relationship with Jeffrey Epstein and his accomplice Ghislaine Maxwell. A6

Loan restrictions Colleges are rushing to help students with tuition ahead of new limits on how much parents can borrow. A7

THE NATION
In Texas, a state hearing on a new school curriculum became a clash of religions. A4
The CDC is delaying a report showing covid vaccine benefits, fueling suppression fears. A5

THE WORLD
The wildlife trade is causing outbreaks of disease across the globe, a study concluded. A10
As the TACO meme takes hold, questions rise over how to translate "chicken out." A13

THE ECONOMY
Taking short breaks from social media may reverse cognitive decline, studies show. A18
U.S. stocks rose, even though oil prices did too, as financial markets moved more modestly a day after surging on optimism about a ceasefire in the war with Iran. A18

STYLE
A dirty marketing trick in "The Drama": A "no spoilers" ploy hypes a "twist" that really shouldn't be a secret. B1

SPORTS
NFL teams try to gain insight into how young players will react to having money before they get a big pro contract. B7

THE REGION
Three former medical staff members at D.C.'s only for-profit psychiatric hospital have been indicted in the 2020 death of a patient. B13

WEEKEND
The Post's Peeps diorama contest returns with Bad Bunny and a squishy satire of the Oval Office.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A18
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....B16
OPINION PAGES.....A15
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A11

CONTENT © 2026
The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54547

0 170628 211001 3